19
Colonel of the Regiment

During the summer of 2001, besides Exercise Poorna Vijay, there was another important development taking place. And that was the election of the colonel of the Maratha LI, one of the oldest and most renowned infantry regiments of the Indian Army, with a glorious history going back to 1768. The election was necessitated due to the retirement of Lieutenant General V. Oberoi, the vice chief of army staff. Every regiment or corps in our army has traditionally elected a colonel to be their father figure, and to look after their interests. This is the only position in the army where elections take place and as far as the infantry and cavalry are concerned, it is not necessary that the seniormost becomes the colonel. However, the measure of an officer's standing in the regiment is reflected when the ballots are counted. There is a predetermined electorate – all battalion commanders, serving colonels, brigadiers and generals of the regiment have a vote. The commanding officers' vote reflects the mandate of the soldiers. Since our regiment was doing exceptionally well, we had four generals in the fray besides me. This was certainly a record of sorts. It became a matter of life and death for all of us as our regimental reputations were at stake.

Eventually, I was chosen with an overwhelming majority, and I consider this to be a great honour. This was reflective of the high level of trust that all ranks of the regiment reposed in me. I felt humbled, vindicated and redeemed at the same time. My regimental service and extended tenures in command of troops paid off. In a hierarchical and seniority-ridden organization, like armies all over the world, it can become terribly embarrassing for the senior if a junior gets elected. But I wasn't the seniormost! We were all friends